Brand, Marketing & Communications

Writing Guide

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ABN·AMRO

Before we get started...

ABN AMRO is there for everyone who wants to move forward. We encourage action and are willing to address difficult topics. Our communications are personal, warm and attentive, so that clients feel understood.

We also make our expertise accessible, to help people move ahead with practical solutions. This is the mindset behind our writing. But how do you put that into practice?

Even the most experienced writers find it tricky at times, because there are so many choices you can make in the English language.

It's important to ABN AMRO that our communications are clear, transparent and well-considered. As a writer, you might find yourself walking a tightrope. If you're not careful, your language may become reserved, woolly and superficial, while at the other end of the scale it could be too blunt or pushy. The perfect balance is right in the middle: forward-thinking, engaged and smart. This Writing Guide sets out all the rules, guidance and tips you need to get the conversation started. This ensures we always write inclusively, clearly, consistently and correctly.

How to use this Writing Guide

Whether you're working on an email, letter or web page, this guide can be a useful reference document. If you can't remember exactly what you're supposed to do with compound words, abbreviations or gender-neutral pronouns, the contents page and index will take you straight to the information you need. If you're engaging an external copywriter, always send them this Writing Guide.

This document will make your work easier, your texts better and your message clearer. If you have any questions about the Writing Guide or suggestions, email them to redactieraad@nl.abnamro.com

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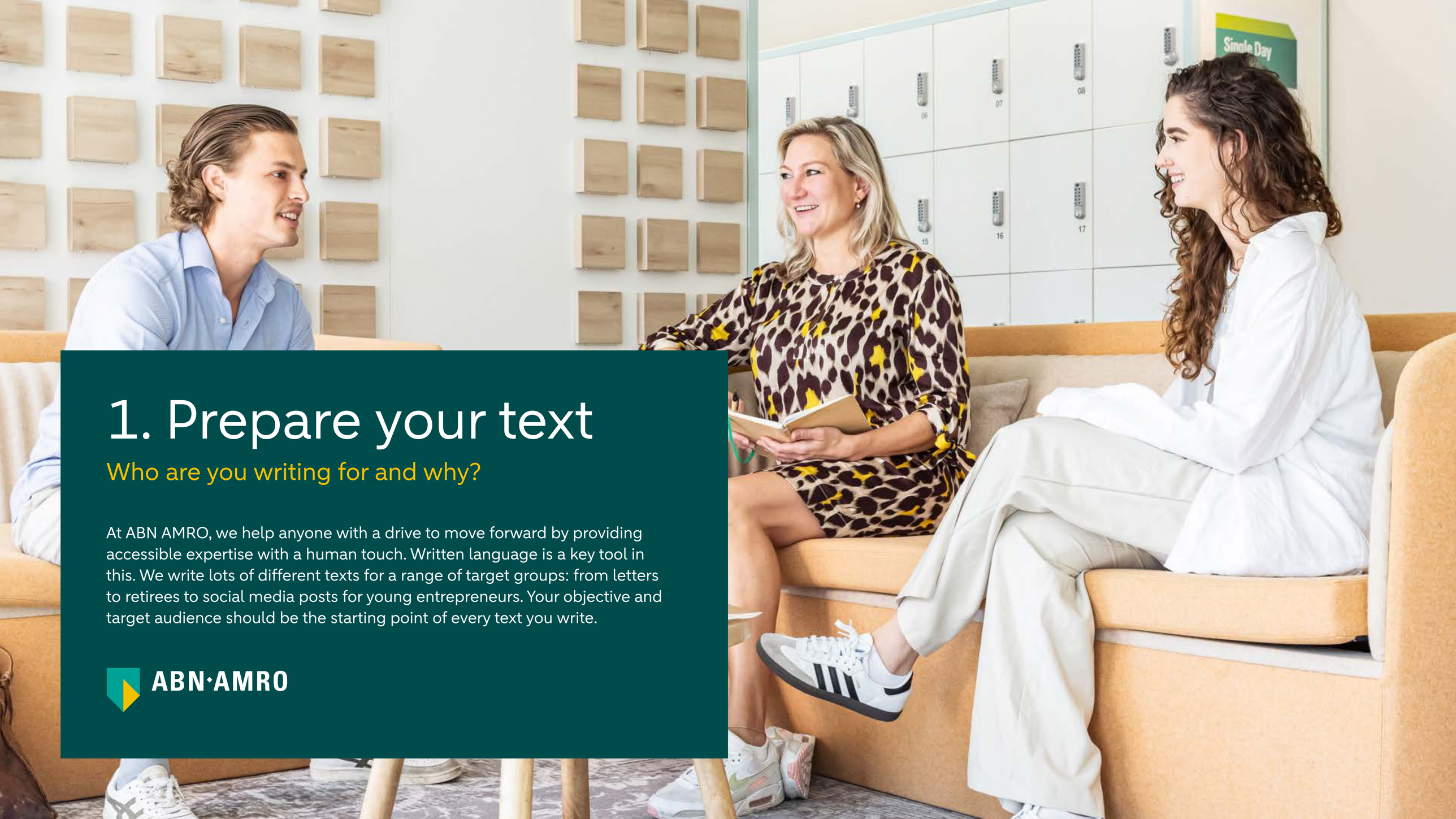

1. Prepare your text

Who are you writing for and why?

At ABN AMRO, we help anyone with a drive to move forward by providing accessible expertise with a human touch. Written language is a key tool in this. We write lots of different texts for a range of target groups: from letters to retirees to social media posts for young entrepreneurs. Your objective and target audience should be the starting point of every text you write.

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1.1 Define your target audience: who are you writing for?

When you write a text, you need to know who you are writing for. The more you know about your readers, the easier it is to align your message with their knowledge, background and expectations. Try to answer at least the following questions before you start writing:

- **What does the reader know about the subject?**
  An experienced investor doesn't need to be told the difference between equities and bonds.
- **How does the reader feel about the subject?**
  If you are communicating a negative or sensitive message, explain it carefully and show that you understand the reader and their point of view.
- **What are the characteristics of your target audience?**
  What is their average age, for example? You should use a different tone to address young people than an older audience. Young people are also more likely to be familiar with the online possibilities we offer.

1.2 Define your objective: why are you writing this text?

The information you provide must always enable your readers to take the next step. But what exactly do they need to do when they have read your text? Formulate your objectives in terms of the behaviour you want to elicit.

I want to:	Objective:
inform	the reader will know [...]
instruct	the reader will be able to [...]
convince	the reader will think that [...]
set something in motion	the reader will take action [...]
create a feeling	the reader will feel [...]

Texts often have more than one objective, and that's fine. But be careful not to cram too many messages into your text or it may become confusing. It should always be clear to your readers what they need to do after reading your text.

Example: think of questions about your text

ABN AMRO wants to receive annual results in digital format only, and will no longer accept hard-copy versions. You are writing a letter to business clients on this. Your aim is to get them to accept the change.

Clients could ask a range of questions:

1. Why does ABN AMRO insist on receiving my annual results in digital format?
2. What are the advantages (and disadvantages) for me?
3. What if I can only submit a hard-copy version of my annual results?
4. Can my accountant submit my annual results in digital format?
5. Where can I find more information about this topic?

1.3 Determine the content: always keep your readers in mind

Once you've defined the target audience and objective of your text, it's time to develop your story. Only provide the information readers need in order to take the required action. This can include things like arguments, information that answers potential questions, or a practical explanation.

Strike the right balance between what you *can tell* readers and what your readers *want to know*. For instance, try to think of questions your readers may have about your message. A good text should usually answer at least the following questions: who, what, where, when, why and how?

1.4 Determine your means of communication: what form will your text take?

There are specific rules and guidelines for some types of text. For instance, a letter will look different from a text on our website.

1.5 Templates

Templates for presentations, newsletters and reports are available in PowerPoint and Word. Templates for letters are available in Word. You can also find our templates in the Brand Bank on SharePoint.

2. Structure

How to structure a text carefully

A good structure is the basis for a clear, effective text. This chapter gives tips on how to develop a story, from the title to the last full stop.

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2.1 Think of a suitable heading

The title is a major factor in determining whether or not readers start reading your text. A good heading:

- indicates what the text is about
- entices the reader to read on
- is clear, concrete and concise

The more whimsical a title is, the less clear it is. So avoid being playful. Creative titles are only acceptable if they are followed by an informative subtitle. Also bear in mind that the more prominent you make the key concepts in your text, the easier it will be to find your text.

Example

Not like this

One swallow doesn't make a summer

Like this

Why one good quarter does not make a difference to your pension investment

Or this

One swallow doesn't make a summer
Why one good quarter does not make a difference to your pension investment

2.2 Put the key message at the top

Most people don't read texts from start to finish. They tend to quickly read the first paragraph and scan through the rest at random. So to give them the essentials right away, you need to put the most important information at the beginning of your text.

2.3 Use paragraphs

Nobody wants to read large blocks of text. Paragraphs keep your text clear and easy to read. Bear these points in mind:

- Don't cram too much into your paragraphs: address one topic per paragraph
- Put the most important information at the top of the paragraph
- Put a subheading above each paragraph
- Use a blank line to separate paragraphs
- To make sure all paragraphs can be read individually, don't use 'this' and 'that' to refer to things in previous paragraphs
- Create paragraphs of at least three lines and no more than seven

Internal communications

If you're writing a text for ABN AMRO colleagues, you don't need to apply the rules above and below as strictly. You don't need to use a subheading above each paragraph, for instance. In fact, it's better not to. And you don't need to put the information in your paragraph in order of importance, as long as the key point is in the first sentence.

2.4 Use subheadings

Give every paragraph a subheading that indicates what the paragraph is about. Here are some tips for subheadings:

- The reader should be able to follow the thread of your story just by reading the subheadings.
- Use bold formatting for subheadings to make them stand out.
- Address the reader in the heading. For example: **How will this affect you?** (not: **How will this affect me?**)
- If the heading contains a question, introduce the answer in the subsequent paragraph.

Example

How do you apply for a mortgage?

To apply for a mortgage, you first need to contact a mortgage adviser. You can then [...]

2.5 Use bullet points

Use bullet points to list items. This is much clearer for readers than a long string of items in the body text. Here are a few tips:

- Leave a blank line between the body text and the list
- Use at least three bullet points and no more than seven
- Readers remember an uneven number of bullet points better
- If you say how many things you are going to list, use a numbered list rather than bullets
- Also use a numbered list when setting out the steps in a process

2.6 Finish with a call to action

At ABN AMRO, we want to help people move forward. If your readers are supposed to do something after they've read the text, finish with a clear, compelling call to action.

Check your text

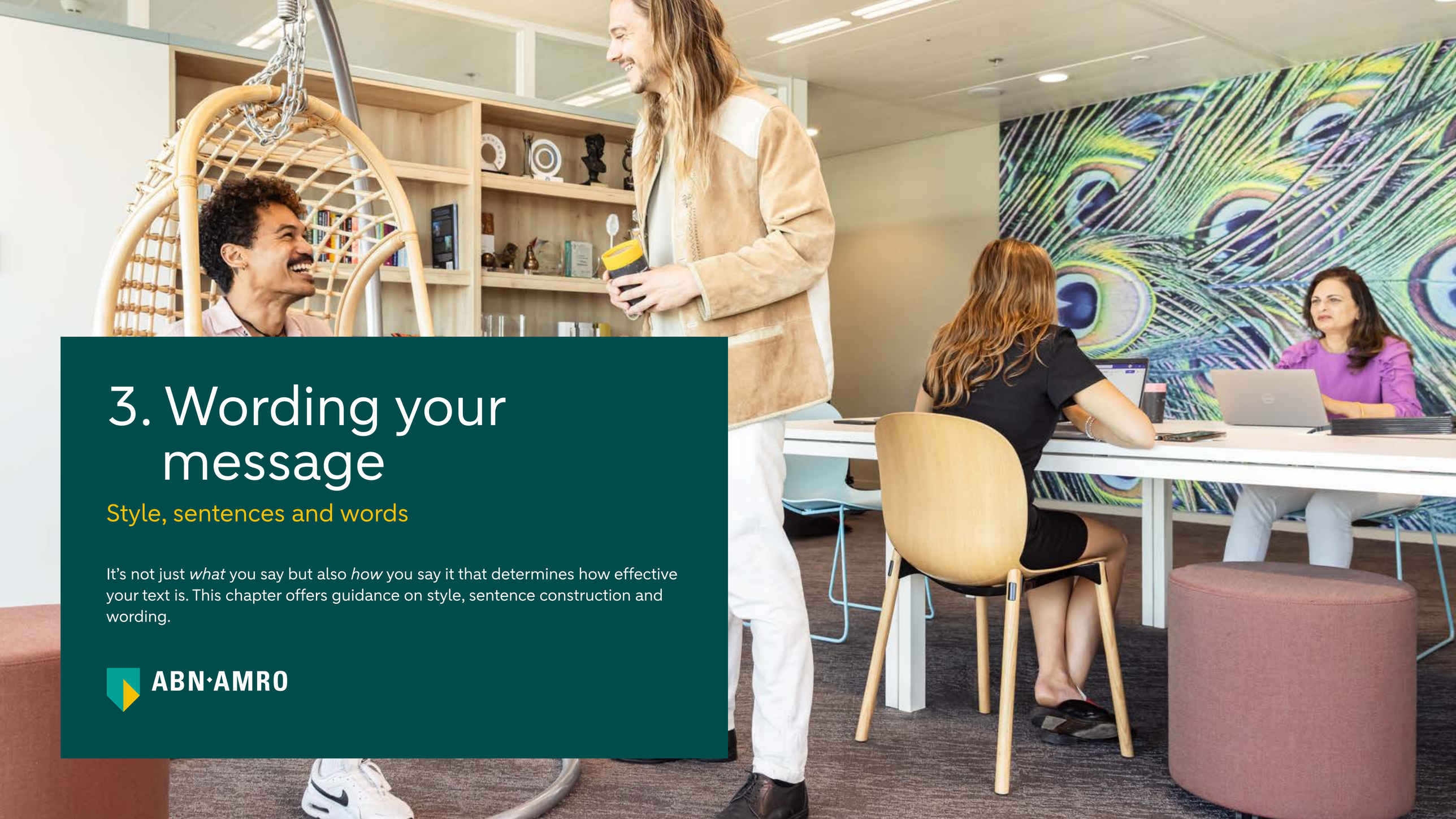
Use the Brand Experience guide via SharePoint to review your text.

Cut your word count

Your text can always be shorter. Check for unnecessary words or lengthy wording. Ask a colleague to read the text too.

Use professional translators

Use professional human translators if you are going to share your text in a language that is not your native language. You can contact the bank's preferred suppliers for this. Machine translation tools like Word translate are good enough for non-critical communications between colleagues, but not for communications to clients, bank-wide internal communications, or branding and marketing materials.



3. Wording your message

Style, sentences and words

It's not just *what* you say but also *how* you say it that determines how effective your text is. This chapter offers guidance on style, sentence construction and wording.

ABN·AMRO

3.1 Style

The way we write strongly affects the way people think about ABN AMRO, so it's an important tool for communicating our brand values. Language can inspire or irritate, weaken a message or highlight painful issues. This chapter outlines the basic principles of ABN AMRO's writing style. While these principles are applicable to all English texts for all audiences, both within and outside ABN AMRO, you should bear in mind that language usage is strongly related to your cultural environment. This is certainly true for our international network, where a text can only be effective if it takes into account the reader's knowledge, cultural background and expectations.

Use plain language

How do you turn professional jargon into 'ordinary' words? That has already been done for a lot of banking and financial terms. Check out the Plain English Campaign's A to Z of financial terms and other free guides.

Communicate in a personal and friendly way

We always treat our clients as equals, also in our communications. We use our texts to share information and advice, but we don't judge the way our clients arrange their finances. We take a personal approach and are always friendly and polite.

Put the reader centre stage

Don't write about internal processes or products, as that will not interest your readers. Put yourself in your readers' shoes and anticipate their questions. Why is this message useful for *them*?

Example

Not like this

'ABN AMRO has a new app.'

Like this

'The new app makes it even easier for you to do your banking online.'

Tell the story honestly

ABN AMRO communicates transparently and clearly. Never withhold information that could be relevant or interesting to your client. Be honest: point out both the advantages and disadvantages.

Avoid greenwashing and making unfounded claims

All information must be correct and clear, and must not be misleading. Specific rules apply to sustainability claims to prevent greenwashing. Sustainability claims are all expressions relating to the sustainability of products, services or business operations in terms of their environmental, social or governance (ESG) aspects. These claims must be accurate, representative, specific, substantiated and up to date. In addition, the information must be understandable, appropriate and easy to find. To align with this, we follow the AFM's Guidelines on Sustainability Claims. See Ruby (Confluence) for more information and examples (in Dutch).

Example

Not like this

'If you suddenly need money, you can overdraw your Privélimiet Plus account.'

Like this

'Your washing machine always seems to break at the worst time – when you've just been on an expensive holiday, for example. Our Privélimiet Plus account lets you overdraw, so you can replace your washing machine right away.'

Include a call to action

Make it clear to clients what they need to do after reading your text. Always use polite language in English when you are giving instructions.

Example

Not like this

'Return this form.'

Like this

'Please return this form.'

Question-and-answer constructions are often used in Dutch but are less common in English and should be avoided, as they can sound unnatural.

Example

Not like this

'Do you need help? Then please contact one of our employees.'

Like this

'If you need help, please contact one of our employees.'

End texts with a concrete call to action: 'Schedule a meeting'; 'Complete the survey'; 'Read more'.

3.2 Sentence construction

In a good text, every sentence hits the nail on the head. These tips will help you formulate sentences with impact.

Write short sentences

~~Many~~ sentences could ~~generally speaking~~ be ~~quite a bit~~ shorter. Short sentences don't overflow with (often superfluous) information and are more readable. The risk of making mistakes in short sentences is also much smaller. As a rule of thumb, aim for sentences of 10-20 words, but make sure you vary the length. A healthy balance of long and short sentences gives a text rhythm.

How to write short sentences

- Look for where you can finish a sentence and start a new one.
- Ask yourself if any comma could be a full stop.
- Avoid using a lot of subclauses between commas, brackets and dashes. Instead, turn a subclause into a new sentence.

Example

Not like this

'Incurring damage might mean you need to pay demolition (or removal) charges – provided this damage is insured.'

Like this

'If your house has been damaged, you might need to pay demolition or removal charges. These will be refunded if your insurance covers the damage.'

Write active sentences

Passive sentences contain constructions like 'has been' + a past participle. Compare: passive, 'You will be called' and active, 'We will call you'. Passive constructions make the text distant and impersonal, and it is not clear who is taking action. Active sentences are more powerful. So always say who is doing what, and when.

Example

Not like this

'The order has been placed by the office manager.'
'The survey was sent out by the customer service team.'

Like this

'The office manager has placed the order.'
'The customer service team sent out the survey.'

Don't turn verbs into nouns

Avoid turning verbs into nouns. This style of writing makes text vague and impersonal, and you should avoid it.

Example

Not like this

'Completion of this form must be done on the same day.'
'The processing of your data will take place tomorrow.'

Like this

'Please complete this form on the same day.'
'We will process your data tomorrow.'

Avoid relative clauses

Avoid using relative clauses to give additional information about the subject of a sentence. Relative clauses make sentences unclear and difficult to read. Starting a new sentence is much more effective.

Example

Not like this

'The interest, which may vary monthly, is payable on the last day of the month.'

Like this

'The interest may vary monthly. Interest is payable on the last day of the month.'

Avoid using double negatives

Double negatives should be avoided because they make sentences abstract and confusing. The reader needs to decode the sentence to understand what you are trying to say.

Example

Not like this

'We have not been informed that the employer did not act according to the regulations.'

Like this

'As far as we are aware, the employer complied with the regulations.'

Make smart use of bullet points

You can replace complicated and lengthy explanations with a bulleted list. Lists add structure to your text and create space. Follow the guidelines in chapter 4, 'Bullet points'.

Example

Not like this

You can increase your borrowing limit if the bank considers your assets to be sufficient. You also need to fulfil the conditions of the bank's loan policy and the additional amount you borrow should be at least €5,000.

✓ Like this

You can increase your borrowing limit if:

- the bank considers your assets to be sufficient
- you fulfil the conditions of the bank's loan policy
- the additional amount you borrow is at least €5,000

3.3 Choosing the right words

Avoid formal language, use everyday words

Plain language uses everyday words that 'everyone' knows. Abstract, formal and difficult words aren't good for your text. They make it vague, distant, unfriendly and even annoying. What's more, formal texts often come across as old-fashioned. So use commonly used words wherever possible. If you can't avoid using a difficult, abstract word, explain it and give an example.

Remember that business language is not the same as formal language, and everyday language is not the same as slang. You can write a business-like text without it sounding too formal.

Be careful about using jargon

We have a tendency to use terminology that is familiar to us, but may be hard for others to understand. Always ask yourself whether there is an easier word to use than professional jargon. And if you do have to use a difficult word, explain what it means.

If you're writing for colleagues, other people in your line of work, or business relations who will definitely understand professional jargon, using jargon is not a problem. Giving too much explanation to these readers may come across as patronising.

Check your text for ambiguity

Sometimes words can be interpreted in more than one way. This can be confusing. References to things and people can also have a double meaning. Check your text for such ambiguity.

Example

'The CEO could not call the secretary because she was not present at the time.'

Who was not present? The CEO or her secretary?

Avoid modal verbs

Try to avoid using modal verbs that express:

- a probability (ABN AMRO may/can/could)
- an obligation (ABN AMRO must)
- a wish (ABN AMRO would like to)

Such nuances are often unnecessary. A sentence is stronger if you avoid modal verbs.

Example

Not like this

'Our employees can explain the most appropriate mortgage in your situation.'

'ABN AMRO is required to report to the Dutch Authority for the Financial Markets (AFM).'

Like this

'Our employees will be happy to explain the most appropriate mortgage in your situation.'

'ABN AMRO reports to the Dutch Authority for the Financial Markets (AFM).'

Tell it like it is

Words that obscure reality include verbs like 'can', 'would like to' and 'shall', and also expressions like 'some', 'mostly', 'try' and 'likely'. We often use these because we want to be courteous or in order to weaken a message. These words, however, are vague, so they don't make a strong impression and they make your text less clear. Only use them when absolutely necessary, from a legal perspective, for instance. The same goes for expressions like 'etc.', 'a number of' and 'among other things'. Be specific about actions and amounts if you can.

Avoid figurative language

Sayings and proverbs are colourful, but they're not precise. Some people can't read very well or may not be native speakers of English. They probably won't know the meaning of certain expressions, so the message will be lost on them. That is why it's better to avoid figurative language.

The section on 'Inclusive writing' in chapter 6 explains how to make sure your text includes everyone.

Aim for consistency

Many writers vary their choice of words. While synonyms make a text more interesting to read, too much variation will confuse your readers. That's why it's important to use the same word for the same term. You can use prepositions such as 'this', 'that', 'these' and 'those' instead of a synonym to make a text more varied. And if you do choose a synonym, make sure the meaning is clear.

Example

Not like this

'You will find the tax return form at the end of this email. You must complete the tax return form in full and then send the tax return form to your adviser.'

Like this

'At the end of this email, you will find the tax return form. Please complete it in full and send it to your adviser.'

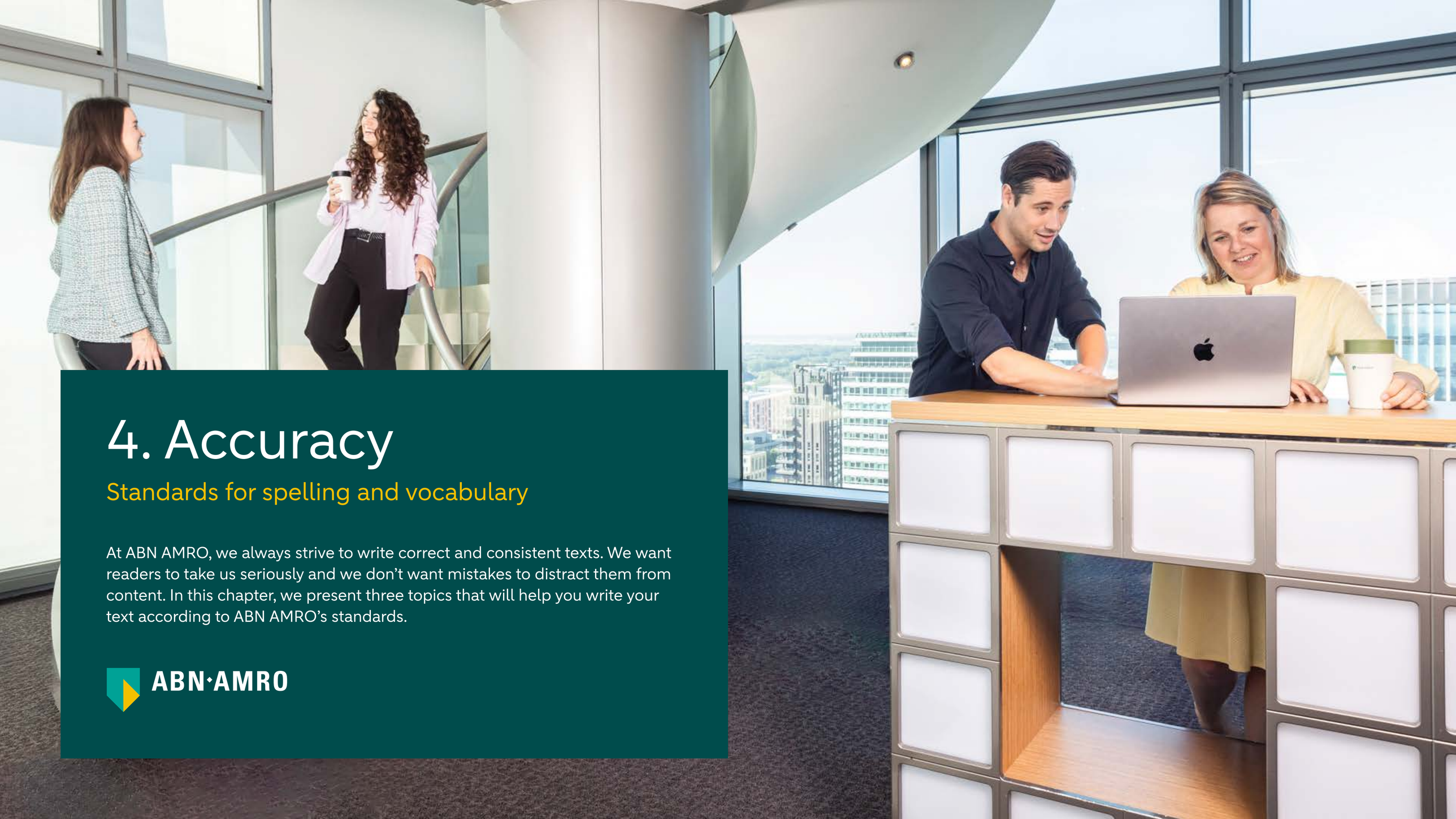
Personal prepositions

- **He/she** – The idea that a person is a man or a woman is deeply engrained in our language, as our personal pronouns show. You should avoid these words. See chapter 6, 'Inclusive writing' for more information.
- **I** – Use 'I' if you are doing something for the client yourself. For example: 'I will send you [...].' If it is the bank doing something for the client, use 'we' or 'ABN AMRO'. Preferably 'we', as that stands out less in the text. For example: 'We have many years of experience with [...]'
    - An exception to this principle is legal texts. In legal language, we prefer 'the bank' to 'we'.
- **One** – Do not use the personal pronoun 'one'. It is not clear who you mean, and it sounds too formal and distant.

Instructions: must, may and may not

Many of our texts instruct readers to do something. Examples include product terms and conditions for clients, or work instructions for colleagues. These texts clearly set out what is possible and permitted, and what isn't. Use the following wording:

Reason	Wording	Example
Something is mandatory	In policies or instructions to employees: 'you must' or the imperative. When writing to clients: 'Please make sure you...' or 'Please note that you must...'	'In case of an emergency you must use the stairs.' 'To take advantage of this offer, please make sure you return the signed form to us.'
Something is not mandatory	'you do not need to' or 'optional'	'You do not need to attend the meeting.'
Something is permitted	'you may'	'You may use the following abbreviations in client correspondence.'
Something is prohibited	'not permitted'	'Staff are not permitted to smoke on these premises.'
Something is permitted under certain conditions	'only if'	'Use email only if [...].'



4. Accuracy

Standards for spelling and vocabulary

At ABN AMRO, we always strive to write correct and consistent texts. We want readers to take us seriously and we don't want mistakes to distract them from content. In this chapter, we present three topics that will help you write your text according to ABN AMRO's standards.

ABN·AMRO

4.1 Standards for spelling and vocabulary

Spelling and vocabulary standards are listed below in alphabetical order. Our standard is to use British rather than American English.

Abbreviations

Abbreviations are not the best way to save space because they make a text harder to understand. Avoid abbreviating unnecessarily.

If a long term is frequently used in your text, it may make your text awkward to read. In that case, abbreviating the term may be the best solution. To abbreviate a term, write out the words in full when the term is first mentioned, followed by the abbreviation in brackets; for example: 'independent software vendor (ISV)'. After that, use only the abbreviation, but try not to repeat it too often. If an abbreviation or acronym is so familiar that it is used more often than the full form (for example: 'US', 'EU', 'IMF'), you do not need to give the full form at all. If an organisation has formalised an abbreviation of its name, use that spelling (for example: iDEAL).

Abbreviations you may use

Here are some examples:

- 'kg', 'km' (use lower case)
- 'Ltd.' And other commonly used corporate abbreviations
- Mr, Mrs, Ms (without full stop)
- Currencies such as 'USD' and 'EUR'; always in capital letters, although ABN AMRO uses 'dollars' and 'euros' lower case (see under 'Amounts' in chapter 4.1)
- **Only in informal writing:** e.g. (short for 'exempli gratia', which means 'for example'); use lower case
- **Only in informal writing:** i.e. (short for 'id est', which means 'that is'); use lower case
- **Only in internal communications:** 'BO number'
- **Only in charts and tables:** quarterly, half-year and nine-month abbreviations of dates, for example 'Q2' (not: 2Q). In other texts spell out: 'second quarter'
- '&' – only use this symbol if it is part of an official name (example: EU Affairs & Market Infrastructure). It is preferable to write out the word 'and' instead

Also see 'Abbreviations' in chapter 4.2, 'Tricky words and common mistakes'.

ABN AMRO brand name

'ABN AMRO' is used as a stand-alone brand name or together with a sub-brand or label. The following rules apply:

- Use the correct brand name. The complete legal name is 'ABN AMRO Bank N.V.' We generally use the commercial name 'ABN AMRO'. Alternate this with 'we' or 'us' to make your texts sound less formal. Never use 'ABN AMRO bank'.
- Do not use 'the bank' in texts for clients: this could refer to any bank. Legal text is the exception to the rule, when referring to the terms and conditions of our products. 'The bank' can be used in these cases as its meaning has been defined at the beginning of these documents.

- Units of the bank that are an independent legal entity are written with ‘ABN AMRO’ before the name of the unit or activity, and the first letter of the unit or activity itself is capitalised. For example:
    - ABN AMRO Foundation
    - ABN AMRO Clearing
    - ABN AMRO Hypotheken Groep

  Note that names of divisions are not translated.
- ‘ABN AMRO’ is not used in combination with department names.
- Do not combine our brand name ‘ABN AMRO’ with a product name. For example, write ‘ABN AMRO’s student account’ rather than ‘ABN AMRO Student Account’.
- Our name must be capitalised and written in full, without a forward slash, underscore or hyphen. Do not write ‘ABN’, ‘ABN/AMRO’, ABN_AMRO’ or ‘ABN-AMRO’. When merging component parts, do not use a hyphen in English: ‘ABN AMRO office’.
- With sponsorship projects, it is essential to create a direct link between the project and our brand name. If ABN AMRO is the principal sponsor of a project, we put the name ‘ABN AMRO’ before the name of the project or event, and we capitalise the name of the sponsorship project. For example, ‘ABN AMRO World Tennis Tournament’ and ‘ABN AMRO Art Prize’.
- Never split ABN AMRO, or its sub-brands, labels or endorsements, across two lines. This also applies to ‘ABN AMRO MeesPierson’, for example. To make a non-breaking space between ‘ABN’ and ‘AMRO’:
  in Windows: press Ctrl + Shift + Spacebar
  on a Mac: Option + Spacebar.
- The media often refer to us as ‘ABN Amro’. When quoting from an external publication, do not correct this spelling.
- In English we use ‘its’ and not ‘her’ when referring to the bank and its employees.

More about the use of our brand name

Would you like to know more about how to use ‘ABN AMRO’, for example in combination with our logo? You can find the information in the Brand Bank on the intranet.

If you want more information or have any questions on this, please write to brandreputation@nl.abnamro.com.

Accents

- Add accents to foreign words now accepted as English when they make a crucial difference to pronunciation, such as née, cliché, communiqué (but not to words like elite, role and feted). Once you have decided to use an accent, be consistent: protégé, résumé.
- English does not use an accent to emphasise a word. Use alternative expressions to provide emphasis. For example: ‘...as well as...’, ‘both... and...’, ‘not only..., but also...’. You can also italicise the word to emphasise it. For example, ‘Investors and consumers attended the event’.

Amounts (written in numerical form)

Use the euro symbol (€) in front of amounts. Write round amounts without decimal points (€ 100), except in tables. If a table includes both round numbers and tenths of amounts, add a decimal point and two zeros after the round number: '€ 100.00'.

Where you cannot use the euro symbol, write 'euros' after the amount.

Bank account numbers

Dutch IBAN numbers are written in groups of four characters, separated by a space:

- NL05 INGB 0123 4567 89
- NL91 ABNA 0123 4567 89
- NL54 RABO 0123 4567 89

The first two characters are the country code; the following two a security code; the next four a bank code, followed by the bank account number.

Many non-Dutch IBAN numbers are compiled differently. For example:

- Belgium
  Bank: 321-4567890-03

Branch or office

We use the word 'branch' or 'branch office' when writing about our retail offices. We do not say 'bank office' or 'bank shop'. We use 'office' to refer to all non-retail offices.

Bullet points and numbered points

When using bulleted or numbered points, we want to be consistent within the list as well as with other bulleted or numbered lists in the same document or website.

Stick to the following rules:

- If the list only consists of keywords or sentence fragments, begin with a lower-case letter.
- If the list consists of one full sentence per point, begin each sentence with a capital letter and don't use full stops.
- If the list consists of more than one full sentence per point, begin each sentence with a capital letter and use full stops after all sentences in the list.
- Use a question mark after the components of a list if they are formulated as questions.
- Write a line of introduction for the list. Do not use a subheading as the introduction.
- Do not precede the last bullet point with 'and' or 'or', except where necessary (for example in some legal documents).

Example 1: Bullets with keywords

Our department has three focus areas:

1. answers
2. support
3. advice

Example 2: Bullets with sentence fragments

Our department focuses on:

- answering questions
- supporting other departments
- giving advice

Example 3: Bullets with one full sentence per point

Our department has various focus areas:

- We answer questions
- We support other departments
- We give advice

Example 4: Bullets with one or more full sentences per point

Our department has various focus areas:

- We answer questions. This includes questions from customers and from other departments.
- We support other departments. We provide our help within 24 hours.
- We give advice. This can be both solicited and unsolicited advice.

Capital letters

When do we use capital letters? ABN AMRO's standards are listed below:

- **Proper nouns:** when proper nouns are capitalised in English, only significant words in the heading are capitalised (not short words such as 'of' and 'the'). Examples are the University of Amsterdam, the Secretary of State.
- **Department names:** always capitalise, for example Group Compliance, Group Sustainable Development, Press Office. However, when referring to the business area or market segment, no capitals are needed, as in: 'Group Sustainable Development concentrates on **sustainable development**.'
- **Government and politics:** organisations, ministries, departments, treaties, acts, etc., generally take capital letters when their full name is used. For example: Ministry of Finance, Health and Safety at Work Act. Do not capitalise descriptions: the French **parliament**, the American **finance department**, etc. The full names of political parties take capitals: Labour Party, Republican Party. Their members are also capitalised: Liberal Democrats, Republicans, etc.

- **Months and days of the week:** these always begin with a capital letter in English, as in: Sunday 10 November 2014.
- **People:** no general rules apply to ranks and titles, but as a rule of thumb, capitalise when written with a name. Examples: President Obama, King Charles, the Duke of Edinburgh.
- **Abbreviations:** when shortened from more than one word, abbreviations are usually capitalised (PDF, AI, NGO). Note that lower case is used for measures (kg, km, mph). Acronyms are capitalised, for example UNESCO. Also see chapter 4, 'Abbreviations'.
- **Headings:** only the initial letter of the first word in a heading or subheading is capitalised, unless it includes proper nouns or names.
- Use capitals for actual geographical places, regions, areas and countries, and for recognised political or geographical areas: the Middle East, Eastern Europe, Southeast Asia, North Africa, the West Bank, the Far East.
- Do not use capital letters to emphasise a particular word. Readers may regard this as exaggerated.
- Use lower-case for north, south, east and west: 'the wind is blowing from the west'; 'I'd like to go south, to the sun'.
- Write the following words with lower-case letters (except at the start of a sentence): internet, intranet, online, email, website.

Contractions

In the past, contractions ('they're', 'don't', etc.) were considered inappropriate for written text and were avoided. Now they are generally accepted and may be used when writing in a friendly, approachable way. This applies to most ABN AMRO texts. Legal or very formal texts are an exception and contractions should not be used for these.

Compound words

In English, combinations of words are generally not joined: 'bank account', 'team leader', 'working day'. Likewise, they are not hyphenated where they would be in Dutch: 'IT department', not 'IT-department'.

Note that combinations of words that together become an adjective to the noun that follows may be written together or hyphenated: 'teambuilding exercise', 'end-of-year review'. When in doubt, however, write them separately.

Currencies

For amounts written in numerical form in tables, we use the ISO currency code (EUR). In tables that also include other currencies, use ISO currency codes for all currencies ('USD', 'GBP').

For amounts written in numerical form in running text, we use the euro symbol (€). In English, we put a space between the symbol and the amount. Where you cannot use a symbol, for example in emails, where the symbol may distort in the recipient's message, write 'euros' after the amount. For example: Save € 25 with this offer. Or: Save 25 euros with this offer.

Note that in financial reporting, ISO currency codes are the standard, even in running text.

Customer or client

Although these terms can often be used interchangeably, ABN AMRO always uses the term 'clients' except in the following cases:

- We use 'customer' when talking about the customers of our clients. For example, 'the customers of the supermarket we finance'.
- 'Customer' is used in standard combinations such as 'customer journey' and 'customer experience'.
- Certain ABN AMRO department names also use customer. For example, Customer Care & Operations.

Dates

The following rules apply when writing dates:

- Use British English style for dates: day month year and no commas. For example: 21 September 2017, with a non-breaking space (Ctrl + Shift + Spacebar in Windows, Option + Spacebar on a Mac) between the day and the month as well as the month and the year.
- Don't abbreviate names of months in text, as in 12 July 2017, September 2017. An exception may be made for tables and charts. In date abbreviations, always use two digits for the day and month (adding a zero if necessary), and four digits for the year. For example: 21-09-2017.
- To indicate a period of several years, use the following style: 2010-2017, 1990-2017. 'From' must be followed by 'to'. Don't write 'from 1995-2000'. Write either 'in 1995-2000' or 'from 1995 to 2000'.
- Don't use an apostrophe for '1800s', '1990s'.
- Months and days of the week always start with a capital letter.

Departments

A departmental name starts with a capital letter. The 'd' in 'department' is lower case, as in: 'the Credit Support department'. Even better is to avoid using the word 'department'. Don't connect the 'ABN AMRO' brand name to the departmental name. Incorrect: 'ABN AMRO Credit Support'. Words like 'district' and 'region' also begin with a lower case 'd' and 'r'.

Euro

This is how we use the word 'euro'.

- Use the word 'euro' in the same way as 'dollar', for example: 'convert from dollars to euros' or 'it costs 10 euros'
- Write composite words using the 'euro' as separate words, without hyphenation: '10 euro note', 'euro rate', 'euro cent', 'euro option'
- In English we use 'it' when referring to the euro: 'the euro and its exchange rate'

Fractions

Here is our guidance on fractions:

- Don't use fractions for amounts and percentages. Instead, use decimal numbers and make sure you use a decimal point, not a comma: '0.275%' (no space before %; see chapter 4.1, 'Percentages').
- In all other cases, write the fraction out in full. For example: 'half of the proceeds', 'a third of the text'. Note that fractions are hyphenated when written out: one-third, four-fifths, three-hundredths: 'three-quarters of the readers'.

He, she or it

With the exception of ships, which are female, English does not refer to inanimate objects or abstract entities as ‘he’ or ‘she’. Use ‘it’ when talking about ABN AMRO, for example: ‘ABN AMRO presents its annual results.’

Hyperlinks

Apply these guidelines when you use hyperlinks:

- Only use hyperlinks if the hyperlinked information adds value.
- Write a hyperlink like this: ‘abnamro.com’ (without the ‘http://www’ prefix).
- When linking to a page on abnamro.nl or abnamro.com in written text (not online):
  - Always use an abbreviated URL. This is a shortened link that is easy to remember.
  - Only introduce an existing abbreviated URL. Check first with Digital Banking at digibank.copy.specialists@nl.abnamro.com to make sure that the URL you are giving your readers actually exists and will not leave clients with a broken link and an error message.
  - Where a URL is given at the end of a sentence do not put a full stop after it, to avoid inclusion of a full stop and a subsequent error message. Or put the URL in the middle of your sentence.

Examples: abbreviated URL in your text

Not like this

‘For more information please visit abnamro.com/sustainability.’

Like this

‘See abnamro.com/sustainability for more information.’

- Https addresses need to be written in full, including ‘www’.
- Formulate hyperlinks in such a way that readers know the kind of information the hyperlink can provide and its relationship to the text, as in: ‘Read the *Becoming a Client* brochure’. Do not use links like ‘Click here’ or ‘Go to the next page’.
- Ensure that readers have access to relevant information through the fewest possible clicks. Use deep links whenever possible. If this is not possible, link to the homepage of the relevant website and set out the search steps that readers need to follow. Use ‘>’ between each step of the search path. Example: ‘You can find the Brand Bank under: IT & Facilities > Brand and house style > Brand Bank.

Job titles

These are the rules for job titles:

- Official job titles are capitalised. Examples: Director, Chief Financial Officer, Chief Operating Officer, Chairman, Head of Operations.
- The word ‘member’, when referring to an ABN AMRO Supervisory Board, Executive Board or Executive Committee member, is not capitalised. The word ‘Board’ is. Example: ‘All Board members will meet.’
- When referring to a position in general, do not use capitals. Examples: ’editor’, ’private banker’, ‘project manager’.

Note that a department name is always capitalised, while the word ‘department’ is not. Example: the Credit Risk department.

Names of forms

Names of forms should be capitalised. Also add the word ‘form’ with this first use, if it is not already included in the form name: ‘the Savings Account Application form’. For subsequent mentions, use a keyword to refer to the form, for example ‘the application form’ or ‘the adjustment form’.

Numbers and digits

Express the numbers below in words, not in digits:

- Zero to nine inclusive
- ‘One thousand’, ‘one hundred thousand’, ‘million’, ‘billion’ and ‘trillion’ and multiples thereof up to nine, as in: ‘three hundred’ or ‘ten thousand’

The above guidelines also apply to words such as: ‘first’, ‘second’.

Note: numbers are separate words in English and are not written as a plural, as in: ‘two million’ and ‘23 billion’. However, when they are used generally, without a specific number or currency sign, they are plural, as in: in thousands, in millions, in billions.

Example: writing numbers in full

Four hundred; seventy; seven-point scale; he is the fourth; the Ninth Symphony; top ten; nine kilos; three metres; five litres.

Example: large numbers

In English, thousands are separated by a comma: 1,000 or 10,000 or 100,000 or 1,000,000 (or 1 million).

Never start a sentence with a numerical digit. Rephrase the sentence or write the number in words, as in: '**Ten** new employees have joined the department.'

Use digits (not words) in the following cases:

- Decimals (2.25)
- Percentages (8%) (see also 'Percentages')
- With units of measurement (8 m, 3 km)
- A range of numbers (9-10%); also, write 13,000-15,000 rather than 13-15,000
- Tables
- Age, as in: 'his 9th birthday', 'its 50th anniversary'
- Page numbers
- If the number is an important part of your message, as in: 'Enter your 5-digit identification code'
- In precise or professional announcements, as in: 'It will be 31 degrees tomorrow.' 'The speed limit here was 50 miles an hour.' 'The fever broke after 2.00 pm.'
- If there are low as well as large numbers in the same sentence: 'We received 67 letters of application, 9 of which contained serious spelling errors'.
- In a list.

Example: commas and decimal points

In English-language documents, commas and decimal points must be used as follows: one thousand, five hundred and twenty-eight euros and fifty cents: EUR 1,528.50.

Example: decimals

Make sure there is a digit before a decimal point. If the number in question is between 1 and -1, there should be a zero before the decimal point. Example: 0.023.

Percentages

We use 'per cent' (not the US spelling 'percent') in body text when the number is written in full (example: six per cent). In columns and tables we use '%'. Never add a space between the number and the percentage symbol. Express percentages as follows: '8.75%'. Incorrect: '8¾%', '8.75 per cent' or '8.75 %'.

PIN

PIN stands for Personal Identification Number and is sometimes redundantly referred to as PIN code. We write PIN (in capital letters).

Security

The word ‘security’ often crops up in texts referring to ‘internet banking’ or ‘mobile banking’. Key to any text about security is the concept of ‘collaborative effort’. This enables us to make it clear that ABN AMRO is deeply committed to security and that we expect our clients to do their bit.

When it comes to security, we want to manage client expectations. This is why any text on the subject of security must be approved by your own Legal department as well as by Compliance.

Constructions we use with respect to ‘safe’ and ‘security’ include:

- [...] ‘you will be better protected against criminal behaviour’
- ‘ABN AMRO is constantly striving to protect you against this type of fraudulent behaviour’

We do not write about this sensitive issue in absolute terms and we do not want to give our clients the sense that they are 100% safe if they bank with us. The issue at hand is improving security.

We do not say:

- ‘You are optimally protected’
- ‘Your account is 100% safe’

Spaces

Never use more than one space at a time. Certain combinations of words, dates or figures must always be together on one line. You can do this by inserting a non-breaking space. Press Ctrl + Shift + Spacebar in Windows, Option + Spacebar on a Mac.

Always insert a non-breaking space in the following cases:

- Between area and extension codes in a telephone number: +31 (0)20 630 45 01
- In dates between the day and the month as well as the month and the year, for example: 21 September 2014
- Between the components of a personal name (between ‘Harry’ and ‘Potter’)
- Between ‘ABN’ and ‘AMRO’ and, for example, between ‘ABN’ and ‘AMRO’ and ‘MeesPierson’
- Between the ISO code (for example ‘USD’) and the subsequent amount
  Between the currency symbol (for example ‘€’) or ISO code (for example ‘EUR’) and the amount
- Between ‘Basel’ and ‘II’ or ‘III’

Never use a space:

- Before a punctuation mark
- Between a digit and the percentage symbol % (‘8%’)
- Before and/or after a slash or backslash

Fixing double spacing

Double spaces look messy in any text. Remove them in Microsoft Word with the help of ‘Find and replace’ in the ‘Editing’ box of the ‘Home’ bar (or Ctrl-H). Insert a double space in ‘Search’ and a single space in ‘Replace’. Then select ‘Replace all’. Microsoft Word then automatically removes all double spacing.

Spelling tips

- Look up the correct spelling in a good dictionary. ABN AMRO recommends the Concise Oxford Dictionary, the Oxford Guide to the English Language, the Collins English Dictionary and the Collins Cobuild English Dictionary. The latter is particularly useful for non-native speakers of English.
- Always use the Microsoft Word spellchecker to help avoid spelling mistakes, but be aware that the spellchecker does not consider the context of words. Ensure that you have selected British English as the source language by pressing 'Review' > 'Language' > 'Set Proofing Language' > 'English (United Kingdom)'.
- Use the Microsoft Word AutoCorrect function, to be found under 'File > Options > Proofing' in the toolbar. You can add frequently used combinations of words or names of people, brands or products.

Conjugating verbs: a refresher

Unsure about the spelling of a verb? The British Council website has a useful list of irregular verbs.

Telephone numbers

Dutch telephone numbers are written as follows:

- 0123 45 67 89
- 070 123 45 67
- 06 12 34 56 78
- 0900 0024

International telephone numbers are written as follows:

- +31 (0)20 123 45 67 (Netherlands)
- +31 (0)6 12 34 56 78 (Netherlands)
- +49 (0)123 45 67 89 (Germany)
- +33 (0)123 45 67 89 (France)

The charge for the call is added in brackets after the number, as in: '(local charge)' or '(€ 0.10 per minute)'. Remember to include this information both for telephone numbers in body text and for telephone numbers in the acknowledgments.

For external numbers, always use a non-breaking space (Ctrl + Shift + Spacebar in Windows, Option + Spacebar on a Mac) between the country code, area code and individual extension number.

Time

Time is expressed using the 12-hour clock as follows: '8.10 am' or '4.15 pm'. Do not use '15.15 hours' or 'quarter past three'. Always use a full stop between the hours and minutes, not a colon. Note that there is a space before 'am' and 'pm'.

Note the following difference with the 24-hour clock:

12.00 = 12 noon and 24.00 / 00.00 = 12 midnight
12.01 = 12.01 pm and 00.01 = 12.01 am.

4.2 Tricky words and common mistakes

This section provides an alphabetical list of words that often pose a problem for writers of English, in particular Dutch native speakers. You will also find some general linguistic explanations and tips. Our standard is to use British rather than American English. For a brief explanation of the differences between the two, see chapter 4.3, 'Differences between British and American English'.

A or an

The use of 'an' is governed largely by the pronunciation of the initial letter of the word it precedes (either consonant or vowel). Examples: a euro, a European, a useful tool, an instrument, an IPO.

Use 'an' before a word starting with h only if the 'h' is silent. Examples: a hero, a hotel, an honour, an hour, an honorary.

Abbreviations (incorrect)

The following abbreviations are never used in English:

- 'O.a.', 'a.o.' and 'i.a.' are not used in English. Use 'including' or 'among other things'.
- 'Nr.' is not used in English. 'Number' is abbreviated as no. as in 'Go to page no. 8'. The plural of no. is nos.
- 'Resp.' is not used as an abbreviation for 'respectively'. Always write this in full.
- 'C.s.' is a Latin abbreviation for 'cum suis' and is not used in English. Write 'and others' instead.
- 'C.q.' is the abbreviation for 'casu quo' and is not used in English. Write 'or'. If you need to be more explicit, you could add 'in this particular case'.

General rule: avoid using abbreviations. Also see chapter 4.1, 'Abbreviations'.

Actually

'Actually' in English means 'in fact'. To say that something is happening in the present, use 'currently' or 'now'.

Advice or advise

Advice is the noun. Example: 'to offer advice'. Note: you give 'advice', not 'an advice'. Advise is the verb. Example: 'please advise us immediately'.

Advisor or adviser

An adviser is someone who acts in an advisory capacity. Spell this as 'adviser', as in: 'We aim to be a trusted adviser to our private banking clients.'

Affect or effect

'Affect' is almost always a verb and means 'to have influence on'. Example: 'The results affected his attitude to the company.' 'Effect' as a noun is synonymous with 'consequence'. Example: 'What effect did the news of the takeover have on the company's share price?' 'Effect' as a verb means to 'accomplish' or 'carry out'. Example: 'The consortium effected the takeover last month.'

Agenda

An agenda is a written list of items to be discussed at a meeting. The (electronic or printed) book you use to record your appointments in is called a 'diary' (British English) or an appointment book, date book or calendar (American English). It is also called 'calendar' in Outlook, so use this when referring to Outlook appointments and similar.

America

'America' (or 'the Americas') includes both North and South America. Use 'the United States' or 'the US' rather than 'America'. If you are including Canada, use 'North America'.

Amongst or whilst

Use 'among' and 'while' instead.

Beside or besides

'Beside' is a preposition, meaning 'next to', 'at the side of' or 'by'. Examples:

- 'A house beside the sea.' (by)
- 'She sat beside her friend.' (next to, at the side of)

'Besides' is a preposition, meaning 'in addition to', 'as well as' or 'apart from'.

- 'What are you studying besides English?' (in addition to)
- 'Who was there besides John?' (apart from)

'Besides' can also be an adverb, meaning 'as well', 'furthermore' or 'anyway'.

- 'It's too late to start a round of golf now; it's already getting dark. Besides, it's starting to rain.' (furthermore, anyway)

Bi-annual or biennial

Both are best avoided to prevent confusion. Bi-annual means twice a year, biennial means once every two years. Write 'twice a year' or 'once every two years' instead. Similarly, 'bi-monthly' is ambiguous. Write 'twice monthly' or 'once every two months'.

Centre or center

'Centre' is the British English spelling and should be used in all of ABN AMRO's documents. 'Center' is the American English spelling. Do not change the spelling of 'Center' if it is part of the name of an organisation or building.

Chair or chairperson

Use 'chair', not 'chairperson', 'chairwoman' or 'chairman'.

Compare to or compare with

A is 'compared to' B when you want to stress the similarity. Example: 'He compared the rain to a biblical flood.' A is 'compared with' B when you draw attention to the difference. Example: 'Compared with last year, we had a very bad summer.'

Complement or compliment

If one thing is 'a complement' to another, it goes well with the other thing or completes it. Complement can be used as a noun or a verb. Examples:

- **Noun:** 'The glass of port was a fine complement to the selection of cheeses.'
- **Verb:** 'The two banks' businesses complement each other.'

'A compliment' is a polite remark or an expression of praise. 'Compliment' can be used as a noun or a verb. Examples:

- **Noun:** 'Andrew's manager paid him a compliment on his excellent performance.'
- **Verb:** 'John complimented his colleague on a job well done.'

Comprise

‘Comprise’ means ‘consist of’. ‘Comprise’ does not take ‘of’. Example: ‘The portfolio comprises about 1,500 companies’. If in doubt, use ‘consists of’ or ‘is composed of’.

Council or counsel

‘Council’ as a noun is a group of people that discusses things or governs an organisation or a city. ‘Council’ cannot be a verb. ‘Counsel’ as a noun is someone who gives legal advice. ‘Counsel’ as a verb means ‘to advise’.

Economic, economical or economics

‘Economic’: related to the economy or finances, money matters or wealth. For example: ‘There was a rise in unemployment due to the economic downturn.’

‘Economical’: if something is economical, it saves money or resources. It is similar in meaning to ‘not wasteful’. For example ‘An economical car uses a minimum amount of petrol to drive a maximum number of kilometres.’

‘Economics’: the social science that studies the production, exchange, distribution and consumption of goods and services, as in: ‘He studied economics at university.’

E.g. or i.e.

The following abbreviations are commonly confused in English:

- ‘E.g.’ is short for ‘exempli gratia’, which means ‘for example’. So, ‘e.g.’ indicates an example: ‘She loves to read non-fiction, e.g. reference books and how-to books’.
- ‘I.e.’ is an abbreviation for Latin ‘id est’, which means ‘that is’. So, i.e. specifies and explains: ‘He had one obvious flaw, i.e. his laziness’.

Avoid using these abbreviations in formal writing. General rule is: use abbreviations as little as possible. Also see chapter 4.1, ‘Abbreviations’.

Eventually

‘Eventually’ in English means ‘finally’ or ‘in the end’. For example, ‘He failed his driving test three times, but eventually passed it.’

To suggest possibility, use: ‘possibly’, ‘if necessary’, ‘if any’ or the verb ‘might’. Examples:

- ‘He said he would possibly be able to come.’
- ‘He said he might be able to come.’

Fewer or less

‘Fewer’ refers to countable nouns, and ‘less’ refers to volume. For example: ‘If there are fewer trees, there will be less wood.’ You can have less of something if it is not countable: ‘less sugar’, ‘less money’, ‘less time’. You can only have fewer items of a plural something: ‘fewer men’, ‘fewer shoes’, ‘fewer ten euro notes’.

Note the difference between:

- ‘The less people know about it the better.’ (Meaning: It’s better if people don’t know a lot.)
- ‘The fewer people who know about it the better.’ (Meaning: It’s better if not many people know.)

However

The adverb 'however' should not be used as a conjunction, that is with commas in the middle of a sentence in order to join two sentences together.

Examples of incorrect use:

- 'ABN AMRO's home market is the Netherlands, however, it has operations around the world.'
- 'Net profit in Q1 was lower than expected, however, the outlook is promising for the rest of the year.'

Examples of correct use:

- 'ABN AMRO's home market is the enlarged European Union. However, it has operations around the world.'
- 'Volumes in Q1 were lower than expected. The outlook, however, is promising for the rest of the year.'

Its or it's

'Its' is a possessive pronoun, showing ownership. For example:

- 'Nothing can take its place.'
- 'The company organised a party for its employees.'

'It's' is a contraction of 'it is' or 'it has'. Contractions may be used in informal texts and when quoting a speaker. For example:

- 'I think it's going to snow on Monday.'
- 'It's been a long time since I last saw Ben.'

Italics

Italics should be used for foreign (non-English) words and for the titles of books, brochures, periodicals, exhibitions, films and song titles, as in: 'The *Financial Times* stated on Tuesday that...'

Licence or license

Use the following British English spellings:

- 'Licence' is a noun. Example: 'John got his driving licence last week.'
- 'License' is a verb. Example: 'John is licensed to drive in England.'

Life or live

'Life' is a noun: 'I want my kids to have a better life.' The plural of life is lives (rhymes with 'strives'): 'My children all have better lives than I had.' 'Live' (rhymes with 'strive') can be an adjective: 'The new website went live yesterday.' 'Live' (rhymes with 'give') can be a verb: 'I want to live in New York.'

Lose or loose

'Lose' means 'to fail at' or 'to be unable to find'. Examples:

- 'John would always lose his keys.'
- 'Ann hates to lose at football.'

'Loose' means 'not tight' or 'not fixed in place'. Example:

- 'The railings were really loose and were a danger to everyone.'

Please note or Note

To add a note or point of interest, you can use ‘Please note’ or just ‘Note’. Never use ‘Attention’ or ‘Warning’, as this is too strong in English. ‘Please note’ and ‘Note’ are used more commonly in a running text and are followed by ‘that’.

The Netherlands

- Do not call the Netherlands ‘Holland’, which encompasses only two of the 12 provinces that make up the country.
- Do not capitalise ‘the’, except when at the start of a sentence. Note, however, that it is ‘The Hague’.
- Only use an apostrophe to indicate the possessive, as in: ‘Much has been written about the Netherlands’ unemployment rate.’ (See in this chapter ‘Apostrophes’ and ‘Possessives’.)
- When putting the Netherlands in an alphabetical list, put it under the ‘N’, not the ‘T’.

Possessives

As a general rule, the possessive may be used in the sense of something that may be possessed:

- by a person (John Smith’s, the king’s, the prime minister’s)
- by something that can be personified (ABN AMRO’s, the company’s)
- by a proper noun (London City Council’s)

Add ’s at the end of a singular word to make it a possessive. If the word is in a plural form and already ends in ‘s’, form the possessive in the same way, but omit the second ‘s’. For example:

- ‘The king’s men’ (only one king) becomes ‘the kings’ men’ (the men of several kings).
- ‘The company’s assets’ becomes ‘the companies’ assets’ (the assets of several companies).

Sometimes, there is one owner (singular) that ends in an ‘s’. Use an extra ‘s’ when the sound requires it. For example:

- An extra ‘s’: ‘Mr Jones’s PIN’, ‘James’s account’
- No extra ‘s’: ‘The Netherlands’ flag’, ‘Socrates’ philosophy’

Practice or practise

Use the following British English spellings:
‘Practice’ is a noun, for example:

- ‘Susan runs a doctor’s practice in England.’
- ‘The bank pursues a best-practice policy in key areas.’

‘Practise’ is a verb, for example:

- ‘I practise the piano every afternoon.’

Principal or principle

‘Principal’ as an adjective means ‘important’ or ‘chief’, as in ‘the principal factor’.
‘The principal of a loan’ as a noun is the amount borrowed excluding interest. (Debt repayments are made by paying back the principal.)
‘Principle’ means ‘fundamental’ or ‘general truth’ (as in: ‘in principle’).

Program or programme

Programme is the British English spelling and program the American spelling.
Exception: always use ‘program’ when referring to computer software.

Send or sent

If it's in the present, use 'send'. Examples:

- 'I can send it to you right now.'
- 'I always send my parcels from the local post office.'

Remember: it's never 'to sent' – it's always 'to send'. Example:

- 'I have asked them to send it to me as soon as possible.'

If it's in any form of the past, use sent. Examples:

- 'I sent it to you yesterday.'
- 'The instructions have been sent to the bank.'
- 'She should have sent you the money last week.'

When referring to the future both 'send' and 'sent' can show up in a phrase:

- 'I will send it to you soon.'
- 'Your package will be sent tomorrow.'
- 'I will have sent it to you by next Thursday.'

Shall or will

This is an old distinction, more common in British English than in American English. 'Shall' is used primarily in legal documents; otherwise, use 'will'.

Stationary or stationery

'Stationary' is when something is standing still. 'Stationery' is a piece of paper you write a letter on. Tip: let the 'e' in 'stationery' remind you of 'envelope'.

Suggest

'Suggest' is not followed by an infinitive ('to ___'). 'Suggest' can be followed by a verb ending in 'ing', a 'that' clause or simply a noun. Examples:

- 'I suggest proceeding carefully in this matter.'
- 'I suggest that we proceed carefully in this matter.'
- 'I suggest caution.'

Than or then

Than is used when making a comparison, as in: 'shorter than you'. Then means at that time, or over that period of time, as in: 'First we had dinner, then we went to the cinema.'

Their or there or they're

'Their' is a possessive pronoun. It is used when you want to show that something belongs to someone. For example:

- 'Their new home is in San Diego.'
- 'What is their phone number?'

'There' is used to mean that something is at or in a particular place. For example:

- 'There is a present on the table.'
- 'Look over there to see the ocean.'

'They're' is a contraction for 'they are'. For example:

- 'In my opinion, they're a fine group of athletes.'
- 'They're happy to see me.'

Deciding which word to use is easy if you remember a few simple tips:

- If you can replace the questionable word with ‘his’ or ‘her’, ‘their’ is correct.
- If you can replace the questionable word with ‘here’, ‘there’ is correct.
- If you can replace the questionable word with ‘they are’, ‘they’re’ is correct.

This or that – these or those

‘This’ is used to refer to a single person, place or thing that is close to the speaker. ‘These’ is the plural form of ‘this’. ‘That’ is used when the person, place or thing is more distant. ‘Those’ is the plural form of ‘that’. Examples:

- ‘This computer is easy to use.’
- ‘That woman over there is my boss.’
- ‘These pictures are clearer than those.’

Whose

‘Whose’ can refer to both people and organisations, as in: ‘ABN AMRO, whose profits were announced last week...’. Do not confuse with ‘who’s’, which is a contraction of ‘who is’.

Worldwide

We write this word as one word (ignore your spell checker if it tells you otherwise).

Which or that

The general rule is: ‘that’ defines and ‘which’ informs. Examples:

- ‘James liked the book that had pictures.’
- ‘James liked the book, which had pictures.’

In the first sentence, the information after ‘that’ tells the reader exactly which book James liked: the one that had pictures. This information is necessary to the sentence: the emphasis is on the fact that the book had pictures. In the second sentence, the information after ‘which’ tells the reader additional and non-essential information about the book. The emphasis in this sentence is that James liked the book. The phrase after ‘which’ adds that the book he liked happened to be one with pictures. Note that ‘which’ is typically preceded by a comma, whereas there is no comma before ‘that’.

Your or you’re

‘Your’ is a possessive pronoun, for example: ‘your car’, ‘your phone’, etc.

‘You’re’ is a contraction of ‘you are’, the apostrophe indicating that the ‘a’ is missing, as in: ‘You’re really tall and your spiky hair makes you seem taller!’

4.3 Differences between British English and American English

As ABN AMRO is primarily a European bank, we have chosen to use British English. An exception is made where our texts target an American audience. This section provides an alphabetical list of the differences between British and American English in spelling and in vocabulary.

4.3.1 Spelling differences

‘ae’ and ‘e’ words

Some words can be written with ‘ae’ in British English, while American spelling uses only ‘e’. Check a dictionary if you are unsure.

UK	US
anaesthesia	anesthesia
archaeology	archeology
encyclopaedia	encyclopedia

‘c’ and ‘s’ words

The spelling varies depending on whether the word is used as a noun or a verb. In British English:

Verb	Noun
practise	practice
license	licence

The spelling also differs between British and American English:

UK	US
pretence	pretense
defence	defense

See also: ‘Practice and practise’ and ‘Licence and license’ in chapter 4.2.

Collective nouns

British English treats collective nouns as plural where Americans treat them as singular.

UK	US
‘My family are coming over on Christmas Day.’	‘My family is coming over on Christmas Day.’

Final ‘e’

In British English the final ‘e’ is not removed from verbs before adding ‘-ing’. In correct American English the final ‘e’ is removed before adding ‘-ing’.

UK	US
ageing	aging

‘er’ and ‘re’ words

French-derived words that end in ‘-re’ in British English usually end in ‘-er’ in American English:

UK	US
calibre	caliber
centre	center
theatre	theater

‘l’; single or double?

If a verb ends in a single ‘l’ then the British English ‘-ing’, ‘-ed’, and ‘-er’ forms have a double ‘ll’, whereas the American English forms have a single ‘l’.

UK	US
traveller	traveler
travelling	traveling
travelled	traveled

‘or’ and ‘our’ words:

When a British English word ends in ‘-our’, the American English word usually ends in ‘-or’.

UK	US
behaviour	behavior
colour	color

‘s’ and ‘z’ words

British English uses ‘-yse’ where American English uses ‘yze’. At ABN AMRO we write ‘-ise’/’-isation’ words with an ‘s’ (as does your spell checker if you have set it to English (United Kingdom). American English always uses ‘-ize’ and ‘-ization’:

UK	US
analyse	analyze
criticise	criticize
organise	organize
organisation	organization

ue words

When a British English word ends in '-ogue', the American English word usually ends in '-og'.

UK	US
analogue	analog
dialogue	dialog

4.3.2 Vocabulary differences

The list below provides a few examples of differences between British and American English vocabulary.

UK	US
account card	charge card
bank holiday	legal holiday
barrister/solicitor	lawyer/attorney
bill	check
dialling code	area code
diary, appointment book	date book, calendar
economy (inexpensive plane seats)	coach
full stop (grammar)	period
lift	elevator
opposite	across from
per cent	percent
post	mail
post code	zip code
programme (but: computer program)	program
return ticket	round-trip ticket
ring	call
single (ticket for one journey)	one-way
town/city centre	downtown
underground/tube	subway

5. Punctuation

Getting it right

Correct text is also a matter of attention to detail. A misplaced comma can give a sentence a whole new meaning. This chapter runs through the most important rules, listed in alphabetical order, to help you write your text as correctly as possible.

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Apostrophes

The apostrophe is used to show the possessive case, as in: 'ABN AMRO's profits', 'two weeks' holiday', 'a year's data', 'the member's point of view'. Note that the apostrophe is not used for plurals, dates or abbreviations. Correct spelling: two photos, the 1990s, three MPs.

Brackets

Use brackets sparingly. Preferably, start a new sentence if you wish to clarify, explain or extrapolate.

- Use brackets when defining abbreviations, such as the 'British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC)'.
- Brackets indicate that the words are of secondary importance. (If a whole sentence is within brackets, put the full stop inside.)
- Putting brackets around a word or part of a word cannot be used as an alternative for 'or' and 'and/or', like in Dutch. For example: 'ABN AMRO's (international) operations are flourishing' does not mean that ABN AMRO's national and international operations are flourishing but simply that ABN AMRO's international operations are flourishing.

Colons

Colons are used mainly to introduce an example, a list or bullets. For example:

There are several options:

- a
- b
- c

There is no space before the colon.

Commas

Use commas sparingly. Start a new sentence if at all possible. Use a comma in the following circumstances:

- To separate items in a list, as in: 'The CEO stressed collaboration, revenue growth and low costs.'
- To separate introductory words or a conditional phrase, as in: 'Unfortunately, we were unable to...' or 'If you can understand this, you have no problem at all in using the comma.'
- To separate a phrase that adds expansive information, as in: 'Revenues increased to EUR 327 million, or 44.7%, compared with the same period last year.'
- When quoting someone, place a comma inside the quotation marks, as in: "I would be happy to help you," Hannah said.

Example

Compare the following:

'The advisers, who did not comply with regulations, were reprimanded' (expansive, all advisers were reprimanded)

'The advisers who did not comply with regulations were reprimanded' (limited, only those advisers who did not comply with regulations were reprimanded. No commas here.)

Exclamation marks

Avoid using these, as they feel exaggerated to the reader.

Footnotes: asterisks or numbers

Use footnotes sparingly, as they make your text harder to follow. On top of that, readers tend to skip footnotes. Never provide new or key information in a footnote. Use a footnote to provide additional or background information on a passage in your text, but only if it is impossible to provide the explanation in the text itself. Refer to the footnote by using an asterisk (*). In the event of multiple footnotes, use numbers in superscript ([1]). Never use footnotes in online texts or emails.

Full stops

Use plenty. They make sentences easy to read and understand. Only use one space after a full stop. Never use two full stops at the end of a sentence, even if the sentence ends in an abbreviation. Do not use full stops after 'Mr', 'Mrs', 'Miss' or 'Ms' in British English, at the end of headings or at the end of hyperlinks.

Hyphenation

English compound nouns are usually written as separate words and are rarely hyphenated. Occasionally, a hyphen is used in the following cases:

- Compounds with consecutive vowels: 'anti-inflationary'
- Compounds with certain prefixes: 'non-native', 'ex-partner
- A prefix followed by a capitalised noun or adjective: 'anti-American'
- If a number, a separate letter or a symbol is part of the composite word: '4-way switch'.
- Compound adjectives preceding a noun: 'a well-read book'. Do not use a hyphen if the adjective follows the noun: 'the book was well read'.
- Do not use a hyphen following the prefixes re and pre, except where these are followed by another 'e': re-entry, pre-empt (but reopen and preconceive).

Note: English does not use an omission hyphen to avoid repeating part of the composite word. Incorrect: in- and external communications. Correct: internal and external communications.

Quotation marks

Use double quotation marks when quoting a person, as in: "Any intelligent fool can make things bigger and more complex. It takes a touch of genius – and a lot of courage – to move in the opposite direction." Albert Einstein, 1879-1955. When the quotation is a full sentence, the full stop comes before the close quotes.

Use single quotation marks for:

- A quote within a quote, as in: "The chairman said, 'We will wait for a few more minutes,' and I was in total agreement."
- On-screen messages, such as instructions for system applications.
- Titles of seminars and conferences.

Semicolons

The semicolon is used to mark a pause longer than a comma and shorter than a full stop. When in doubt, use a full stop.

Square brackets

Use square brackets to insert clarifying words into a passage already being quoted. The words within the brackets are not part of the quoted text: The chairman said, "The rate increase [in Belgium] will affect the market."

6. Inclusive writing

Reach *everyone* with your text

At ABN AMRO, we want to help people move forward with action-focused, personal and accessible texts. We don't want to exclude anyone, and language plays a key role. All it takes is one poorly chosen word or inadequate explanation to give a large target group the feeling the text isn't meant for them. But when you succeed in writing without unconscious bias or blind spots, every reader will feel valued, seen and taken seriously.

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6.1 Use plain language

Not everyone in our society finds reading easy. To make sure your message also gets across to readers who struggle, it's important to pay attention to things like jargon, length of sentences, structure and style. Check chapter 3, 'Wording your message' for more information.

6.2 Use gender-neutral language

Attention to gender-neutral, non-sexist language has been on the rise for decades. This has made us increasingly aware of words that can be experienced as biased, discriminatory or derogatory because they suggest that a certain gender is standard.

Gender-neutral pronouns

The idea that a person is a man or a woman is deeply engrained in our language. This is clear from our personal pronouns: 'he', 'she', 'his' and 'her'. You should avoid these words. There are various ways to do this. Let's take the following sentence as an example: 'The bank employee should make sure his/her name badge is always visible.'

- **Use a definite article rather than a personal pronoun**
  'The bank employee should make sure the name badge is always visible.'
- **Address the reader directly**
  'As a bank employee, you should make sure your name badge is always visible.'
- **Use the plural rather than the singular**
  'Bank employees should make sure their name badge is always visible.'
- **Use they/them/their as a singular pronoun. This has become common practice in English**
  'The bank employee should make sure their name badge is always visible.'

Gender-neutral job titles

A lot of job titles suggest that the job is specifically done by a man or a woman. Something else you see a lot is the word 'female' or 'woman' added to job titles when the writer apparently associates a certain job title more with men than with women. Whether they do this consciously or subconsciously, it's certainly wrong, so use a more general, gender-neutral alternative instead.

Gender-specific	Gender-neutral
Businesswoman	Businessperson
Saleswoman	Salesperson / Sales representative

Words with a feminine connotation

Some words have a masculine or feminine connotation that tells you something about the associations many readers have with that word and how they will respond to your text. For instance, words that express something individualistic, competitive, ambitious or assertive are generally more appropriate for men. Research shows that women actually respond better to language that creates a sense of community, social and emotional words, dedication, support, compassion and understanding.

Women have a clear aversion to masculine texts, while men don't mind feminine or neutral language. In light of this, opt for more feminine wording where possible. That way, you'll reach the biggest audience.

Masculine	Feminine
Dominate	Excel
Analyse	Understand
Ambitious, decisive	Dedicated
Independent, individual	Together, cooperative
Dominant, superior	Accessible, polite, sensitive

Use people-first language

You sometimes need to mention a specific group, if you want to say something about people who are deaf or blind, for instance. Always put the person first in such cases.

✗ Not like this	✓ Like this
The blind	Person with a vision/visual disability
The deaf	Person with a hearing disability
Foreigners/immigrants	People with an immigrant background

Avoid unconscious bias

The main point of inclusive communication is keeping unconscious bias and blind spots out of your text, so you don't exclude anybody or make them feel 'different'. Be aware of your assumptions.

✗ Not like this	✓ Like this
Women in the world of finance earn much less.	Women in the world of finance earn much less **than men**.
People with an immigration background have to work harder to get a promotion.	People with an immigration background have to work harder **than people born in the Netherlands** to get a promotion.

In these examples, the first sentence implies a norm, i.e. 'men' or 'people born in the Netherlands'. The other group mentioned in the sentences is portrayed as different, as people who deviate from the norm in the author's view.

The same thing happens when you give people labels, so be sure to avoid these. In most cases, they aren't necessary to get your message across.

✗ Not like this	✓ Like this
working mother	mother
female director	director
manager with an immigrant background	manager

Tip: have a colleague read your text

Being aware of your biases is easier said than done. There's a reason why they're called 'blind spots': often you are unaware that you have assumed a certain norm. So it's a good idea to have a colleague read through your text.

More about inclusive language

Check the UN guidelines to find out more.